

want—right down to the day, service, and vehicle type.” Schedule vehicles translated to: “Maximize your fleet’s road time and receive leads based on your vehicle availability!” Each feature transcribed to a specific benefit that would compel my buyer to join. I didn’t let them fill in the blanks; I filled in the blanks for them.

USING PRICE AS A BRANDING WEAPON

Price is like a paint job for your product or service.

My first taste of “paint” and its implications came young. I wasn’t much older than six or seven. Mom staged a two-day garage sale, and she permitted me to sell some toys and keep the money. One item I offered for sale was a “football clock,” a timekeeping monstrosity. I vividly remember its sale price—\$2.55. A steal, I reasoned.

On the first day of the sale, my football clock gathered many looks, but no sale. My young mind plotted. How can I get \$2.55 for my clock? I didn’t want to budge on my price, surely because \$2.55 was the cost of some gadget I wanted to buy at the corner store. Then I had an idea.

I grabbed the masking tape Mom used for labeling prices. I tore four small pieces of tape and stuck them above the current price. Then on the first piece of tape, I boldly wrote \$5.55 and crossed it out. The next piece of tape I wrote \$4.50 and crossed it out. Then, \$3.95, and the next \$2.95. Each piece of tape successively had a lower price, clearly crossed out so buyers could see the “price reduction,” leaving the same old price of \$2.55.

Now my clock was priced exactly the same, except it was presented differently. The taped higher prices, visibly slashed, conveyed two things: 1) A higher value and 2) A smoking deal. And guess what. The second person to look at the clock bought it. I succeeded at reframing price in the mind of my buyer. Of course, at seven years old, I had no clue what “marketing” meant nor what I was doing. Yet this was my first exposure to marketing and the implication price has to value.

PRICE CONVEYS MORE THAN JUST COST

Price is a brand-builder because *price implies value*. The more expensive your price, the higher its perceived value. The cheaper your price, the cheaper its perceived value. Price isn’t simply a number that tells someone what something costs. It conveys value and worth.

There’s an old story I heard about how price equates to value. Cleaning his basement, a man found an old dresser and decided to give it away. He moved the dresser to the street corner and placed a sign atop it: FREE. Shockingly, the dresser stood there all day, and for several days thereafter. This confused the man because the dresser, albeit old, was in decent shape and just needed a quick wood stain for perfection. The man decided a new strategy was warranted. He went to